On the day Amrik Singh and Thara Singh were arrested, Bhindranwale shifted to the safety of Guru Nanak Niwas to avoid arrest. He also launched a morcha for their release. Meanwhile, the Nahar Roko Morcha was receiving a lukewarm response from the Sikh masses as it was not launched from a gurudwara. So, the morcha was renamed Dharam Yudh (religious war) Morcha and shifted to the Golden Temple. To attract wider attention to his demand, Bhindranwale merged his own morcha with the Dharam Yudh Morcha.

Dharam Yudh Morcha

The Dharam Yudh Morcha was officially launched on 4 August 1982, with Badal leading the first batch of 300 satyagrahis. They were arrested soon after they left the Golden Temple complex. That morcha was conducted in a very civilized manner, and it became a daily routine for the next two and half months. [9]

Moderate Akalis were still in control of the situation, and Harchand Singh Longowal never missed an opportunity to chide anyone who raised slogans in favour of demands not on the Akali Dal agenda. Kuldip Nayar, in his autobiography, writes that he '... attended one of these congregations. When a slogan was raised for Khalistan, Longowal not only condemned it but also said that those who raised the slogan were "agents of the Congress party" and that Akalis were strongly opposed to it.' [10]

Within a period of two months, 30,000 satyagrahis were arrested. The jails were full and makeshift arrangements had to be made. On 11 September, when the police were escorting some detainees to jail, thirty-four of the detainees died when the bus carrying them ran into a train. 'The morcha had caught the imagination of the Sikh peasantry and there was no dearth of Satyagrahis,' according to Kuldip Nayar. [11] But the senior Akali leaders were getting worried that the religious frenzy generated by the morcha might encourage Bhindranwale to take control of it and change its direction towards extremism.